

Oryx gazella

Gemsbok



Location S.W. Africa

Length 5¼–6¼ ft (1.8–1.9 m)
Tail 18¼–20½ in (48–52.5 cm)
Weight 420–530 lb (190–240 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



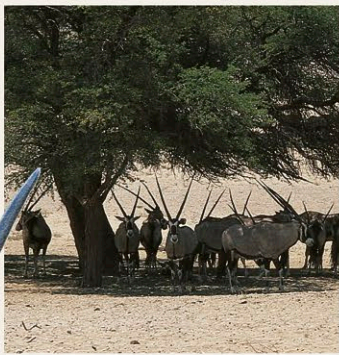
The gemsbok, or southern oryx, is a large, distinctively colored antelope of arid grassy scrub and true desert. Its many adaptations for moisture conservation include not panting or sweating until the body temperature exceeds 113° F (45° C), kidneys that make very concentrated urine, and very dry droppings. The main diet is grasses and low shrubs, with wild cucumbers, melons, and similar plants

supplying water. Nomadic herds of up to 25 contain females, young, and a few males. Like many desert species, gemsbok breed opportunistically, year-round whenever food is available. The single calf (rarely twins) is born after 8½ months' gestation, and stays concealed but near the main herd, with occasional visits from the mother to suckle, for up to 6 weeks.

ringed horns

black lower side stripe

PEACE IN THE SHADE



Gemsbok deal with their hot, dry habitat by grazing at cool times, mainly twilight and at night. They gather in available shade from about 11 am to 3 pm. In most other antelope species, individuals grouped so closely would begin dominance or mating disputes, but gemsbok suspend social interaction for the greater need of survival.

BLACK, WHITE, AND SHADES OF GRAY

The gemsbok has a fawn-tinged gray body and contrasting black and white face, ears, belly, and legs. The broad muzzle and wide row of incisor teeth are adapted to crop coarse grasses.

Addax nasomaculatus

Addax



Location N.W. Africa

Length 3¾–4¼ ft (1.2–1.3 m)
Tail 10–14 in (25–35 cm)
Weight 130–280 lb (60–125 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Critically endangered



Rare and remote, the addax has similar adaptations to the gemsbok (see left) for desert survival. It wanders in search of almost any vegetation, following rains, and rests in shade at midday. Formerly more numerous, a mixed herd of up to 20 was led by an older male; individuals now live alone or in small bands of 2–4. The coat is gray-brown in winter, sandy to white in summer, with a white facial patch topped by a chestnut forehead tuft, and spiral horns (1½–3 turns).



Damaliscus pygargus

Bontebok



Location Southern Africa

Length 4–7 ft (1.2–2.1 m)
Tail 4–23½ in (10–60 cm)
Weight 120–190 lb (56–86 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Also known as the blesbok, the bontebok has a white blaze on its long muzzle, which narrows at the eyes, and continues

rich brown coat has purple sheen

to the flattened, lyre-shaped horns, which are ringed for most of their 28-in (70-cm) length. Adult males posture and spar with their horns—although rarely fight—to gain a territory. This allows them to dominate a herd of females and young. The male keeps its members together and initiates the herd's travels. Females give birth at traditional calving grounds, after a gestation period of about 8 months; unlike many similar antelopes, they do not isolate or conceal their young. The single newborn can walk within 5 minutes, and soon follows its mother; it is weaned by 6 months. The bontebok grazes mixed grasses and herbs, early and late in the day. It was almost exterminated in the wild by the 1830s, but herds were preserved in parks and reserves where its numbers are now slowly increasing.

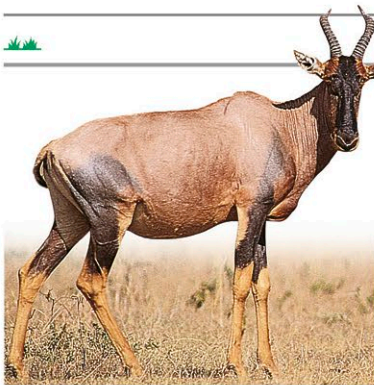
Damaliscus lunatus

Western tsessebe



Location Southern Africa

Length 4–7 ft (1.2–2.1 m)
Tail 4–23½ in (10–60 cm)
Weight 150–340 lb (68–155 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The western tsessebe, or topi, has a long head, a shoulder hump, and a downward-sloping back. Its glossy, red-brown coat is purplish on the upper limbs and darker on the upper muzzle, belly, and lower limbs. It has L-shaped, ringed horns. The western tsessebe lives in seasonally flooded grasslands, and has 2 breeding systems according to conditions: leks (see kob, p.237) in migratory populations; and male territories with harems when resident.

Alcelaphus caama

Red hartebeest



Location Southern Africa

Length 6¾–7¼ ft (2–2.2 m)
Tail 15¾–19½ in (40–50 cm)
Weight 230–360 lb (105–165 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Resembling the western tsessebe (see left) in diet and sloping profile, this is the southernmost species of a genus of hartebeest characterized by heavily ringed horns and prominent glands below the eyes. It has a dark tan coat and curving Z-shaped horns. Like other species, there are paler hip patches and black markings on forehead, muzzle, shoulder, and thighs. Historically, hunting constricted its range, but following reintroduction to southern Africa, it is expanding again.

